



At the Catch of a Ringtone

Forest guards use mobile ringtones to capture rogue leopards wandering into human settlements

■ **By Nandini Valsh**

The clever cat is just so silent. What if we put a bell on it...But the problem is, who would bell the cat?" This predicament from the Aesop's fable is known to school children. The problem remains the same even today but the officials of Gujarat's Forest Department have turned it on its head to find a solution. Instead of belling the cats, they are using bells to ensnare the bigger and the more dangerous members of the species. The bells used this time are more modern—mobile ringtones—which are being used to catch leopards which stray into human habitat in search of food.

The traditional method of trapping big cats involves tying of live bait like goats to trees to lure the animal, which then falls into large pits dug by the guards. The new method eliminates long wait for the animal and having to depend on its olfactory powers to draw it to the bait. Mobile ringtones mimicking the sounds of bleating goats, mooing calves, barking dogs and crowing roosters are now used to draw the animal to the cage. To ensure that the sound reaches where it is supposed to, mobile phones with these ringtones are connected to speakers that are



attached behind the cage with a live animal inside. The tones are played at regular intervals in order to make the sound seem authentic. These sound waves can cover a range of 300-350 m and the method has proved to be effective as the hearing capacity of leopards is high. So far, half a dozen leopards, which either strayed into human habitat or attacked cattle in the Surat district, have been caught. "The animal is drawn to the sound and gets trapped in the cage," says H.S. Singh, chief conservation research officer in the state Forest Department.

One may well ask, why use a live bait, if ringtones are doing all the work? That is because eventually it's the prey that attracts the predator. The ringtone only acts as a catalyst. This trick works best during nights when visibility is low. One of the earlier methods also involved sprinkling droplets of water with the smell of fish along the cat's route or recording the sounds of animals on audio cassette and playing them. Once the latter was successful—the officials caught 12 leopards, including two man-eaters in Baria (Dhule district)—they decided to replicate it using cell phones. The conservationists needn't have any fear as, once caught, the leopards are released back into the forest. ■